2.1 Colonial Protests Grow

You're a young Boston colonist in 1768. "Sorry, son. There's no tea today," your mother says at breakfast. "We're boycotting British imports again." How would you feel about doing without your favorite food or drink to make a point?

MAIN IDEA Britain's attempt to raise revenue and control the colonies through the Townshend Acts led to protests and violence.

THE TOWNSHEND ACTS

Colonists celebrated the Stamp Act's repeal. However, the British government insisted that it had not lost any authority over the colonies. But with the Stamp Act repealed, Britain had to figure out other ways of gaining revenue.

In 1767, Parliament passed the **Townshend Acts**, named after Charles Townshend, a British royal treasurer. The acts placed duties on tea, glass, paper, lead, and paint—all goods that the colonies were required to purchase only from Britain. The revenue from the Townshend Acts would be used by the British to pay the salaries of colonial governors and judges. Previously, these officials had been paid by the colonial assemblies. By paying officials directly, the British government would establish greater control over the day-to-day running of the colonies.

The Townshend Acts also required colonial courts to provide **writs of assistance**, or search warrants, so officials could search houses and businesses for smuggled goods. Writs of assistance had existed for several years, and colonists had protested them. To the colonists, the writs allowed the British to search without cause and to justify random searches, and the Townshend Acts only expanded their use.

THE COLONISTS REACT

Colonists once again protested and accused the British government of tyranny. The protestors were strongly influenced by the 17th century British philosopher **John Locke**, who wrote that a leader could rule only with the consent of the people.

Daughters of Liberty

In the 1770s, colonial women contributed significantly to the anti-British movement. They even spun yarn to reduce colonial dependence on British textiles, prompting Samuel Adams to declare, "With the ladies on our side, we can make every Tory tremble."

This image of a colonial woman holding a flintlock musket appeared on a broadside, a single-sided newspaper, around 1779. A symbol of strength and patriotism, she wears a man's hat, holds her weapon and powder horn, and is pictured in front of a British fort.



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He stated that government exists to uphold natural rights, or rights such as life or liberty that a person is born with. Any government that failed in this task should be overthrown. The colonists strongly identified with Locke's way of thinking.

Samuel Adams was a follower of Locke's philosophy, a member of the Massachusetts Assembly, and a leader of the Sons of Liberty. In 1768, Adams cowrote a letter with lawyer James Otis to the other colonial assemblies. The letter objected to the new duties and proposed a boycott of British goods. The British governor of Massachusetts threatened to dismiss the assembly if it did not take back the letter. Defiantly, the assembly refused, and it was disbanded.

Samuel Adams and the Sons of Liberty vigorously continued to support actions against the Townshend Acts. Colonists in Boston signed an agreement to boycott British imports, and merchants in New York soon followed. Women also used their purchasing power to protest the Townshend Acts. A group called **Daughters of Liberty** boycotted imported tea and clothing. To replace imported cloth, they wove their own fabric, known as homespun, from American yarn and wool.



Tar and Feathers

Sometimes angry protestors used tar and feathers to punish people who supported British taxes. Victims would be dragged to a public place. Then they would be coated with hot, sticky tar and covered in feathers, as shown in this 1774 political cartoon. Tarring and feathering was often portrayed in a humorous way, but it was in fact horribly painful.

The Great Awakening of the 1730s and 1740s also helped push the colonists toward rebellion and independence. During that revival movement, believers challenged the authority of their church leaders. They learned to use their own judgment in matters of religion. The habit of thinking independently spread throughout the colonies. By the 1770s, the ideas of the Great Awakening had helped create a revolutionary fervor among the colonists, which led them to challenge Britain's authority.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How were the Townshend Acts intended to accomplish Britain's goals in the colonies?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** In what ways did Locke's philosophy influence the colonists in their protest against British actions?
3. **MAKE PREDICTIONS** What might result from the boycotts against the Townshend Acts?

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